

on the deal and to pledge their support to her. Mahali even declared that through her clear stand, Mayawati has won the hearts of Muslims even as Rahman, the firebrand Imam of Tilawali Masjid, warned Mulayam that if he did not desist from joining hands with the Congress, a fatwa would soon be issued against him.

In response to this, SP General Secretary Amar Singh, the main architect of the SP-Congress deal, said that the whole world knows that Mayawati has been hobnobbing with the BJP by sharing power with the saffron party thrice in the past. However, Mayawati's move to win over the Muslims suffered a serious setback when Maulana Abdul Khaliq Madrasi, the deputy rector (naib mohtamim) of Dar-ul-Uloom Deoband and Hazrat Maulana Tauquir Raza Khan, the spiritual head of the Bareilly

the table upon Mayawati and the Left by trying to convince the Muslims that not only is the nuclear deal in national interest but that the BJP was a bigger threat to them.

Uttar Pradesh, with 19 per cent Muslim votes, plays a key role in deciding the fortunes of political parties in the Lok Sabha polls. The community had been a strong pillar of Mulayam's Muslim-Yadav combination till Mayawati forged her rainbow coalition successfully. SP is, therefore, planning to announce its Muslim candidates for the Lok Sabha polls, before the trust vote in Parliament to keep its flock

deal but was published when it had reversed its stand.

Major political parties of Jammu and Kashmir, the National Conference (NC) and People's Democratic Party have said that the deal is not against the community. "We do not consider it against Muslims. The deal is either good or bad for the country. Where does the issue of Muslims come here?" said Omar Abdullah, NC president.

The CPI(M) in West Bengal and Kerala too is planning to hit the poll turf with the nuclear deal issue. In northern Kerala with a sizeable Muslim population, the party will play to community

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

THE SP HAS turned the tables on its critics by trying to convince Muslims that not only is the deal in national interest, but that the BJP is a bigger threat.



school of thoughts supported the nuclear deal and snubbed the hand-picked clerics of Lucknow for supporting Mayawati who had "never cared for Muslims". And these men head two of the highly-revered Islamic institutions that can influence many Sunni Muslims in north India.

The Congress, which has been wooing Muslim votes with a slew of schemes, is now trying to diminish the stirring nature of the anti-Muslim theory. The party claims that the Muslim opposition is restricted to the policies of outgoing US President George W. Bush and not with the deal. "Muslims may have an issue with the shopkeeper but not with the product," said Congress spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi. But like the Congress and RJD, SP leaders too seem to have turned

OVERDRIVE: Mayawati has begun to ardently woo Muslim clerics

together. The party is also making use of former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam's endorsement of the deal to counter the anti-minority perception.

Leading Urdu weekly *Nai Dunia*, ironically, owned and edited by SP MP Shahid Siddiqui carried a survey that showed that 70 per cent of Muslims in the country were opposed to the deal. It also said that 85 per cent Muslims considered America their biggest enemy while about 70 per cent felt that the UPA Government has done nothing for the Muslims. The party under the changed situation has rubbished the survey. But the tragedy is that the survey was "conducted" when the party had been against the

sentiments by raising the issue. The Indian Union Muslim League (IUMIL), part of the Congress-led front in Kerala, will find it difficult to hold its turf. The IUMIL, whose sole representative in Parliament is Minister of State for External Affairs E. Ahamed, will be meeting in the coming days to finalise its stand on the deal. The party has been caught between risking electoral backlash and pulling out its man from the Government. The youth wing of the Indian National League, a Left ally, has already demanded that Ahamed should resign from the Government.

Pandhe's fresh gift to Muslim grievance roaster will surely add up to the election planks in the coming Lok Sabha elections. But, so far, there are no clear winners in the first stretch run towards the corridors of power. ■